Original stories and verses

Original language for this curriculum. These are invitations, not required scripts. Choose a comfortable home language, signs, pictures or communication device. Never use a story to frighten, shame or demand obedience.

Infants: use a gentle phrase in actual responsive care and stop with cues. Toddlers: tell one or two real actions, perhaps “The cloth is wet. We put it in the basket.” The six longer stories are starting points for ages three to six, shortened or extended for individual interest.

For older children, tell a familiar story again over several days if welcomed. Retelling may be movement, drawing, dictation, play or speech. A quiet observer can participate without performing.

Seven optional verses

Care greeting • infants

Here I am, and here are you.
I will tell you what I do.

Putting away • toddlers

One cloth resting, one cloth here.
Now the place for play is clear.

Walking • toddlers and older

Slow feet, quick feet, choose your way.
We have room to move today.

Table care • ages three to six

A place for you, a place for me.
Who else is coming? Let us see.

Color • ages three to six

A line can wander, pause and bend.
I choose the place where it will end.

Outdoor pause • any age with adaptation

A little breeze, a changing sky.
We stop a moment, you and I.

Departure • any age

Our time today is nearly through.
One more goodbye, and home with you.

The cloth by the door

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

Mina found a clean cloth beside the door. A little water had dripped from the boots. “That spot is wet,” said the adult. Mina pressed the cloth against the floor. The dark wet patch became smaller. She turned the cloth and pressed again. Then she put the cloth in the wash basket. At the door, another child was taking off boots. Mina pointed to the dry place. “Here,” she said. There was room to come inside.

Teacher use

Useful care; sequence; welcoming another child.

A real cloth for a child-led retelling, kept out of infant areas.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.

A place for one more

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

Four friends made a pretend house. They put four wide paper squares around a box table. Then Eli arrived. “May I visit?” Eli asked with a picture card. The friends looked at the table. Nia moved her square a little. Tom moved his too. Eli chose another square and placed it beside them. Their table was still small, but their circle had grown. They played that a meal was ready. After a while, Eli chose to leave. The friends kept a place for the next visitor.

Teacher use

Accessible communication; counting real places; invitation without forced participation.

Large paper shapes; ask children how they would arrange an accessible play space.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.

The path after rain

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

After rain, Jun and the adult walked their familiar path. The low place held a puddle. “We can look from here,” said the adult. A leaf floated across the water. Jun watched until it rested at the edge. They chose the dry accessible route around the puddle. At the tree, Jun noticed dark bark and shining drops. On the way back, they looked once more. The leaf had turned. “It changed,” Jun said. Tomorrow they could look again.

Teacher use

Local observation; a safe route; noticing change.

Adapt rain to an actual local weather event; no need to enter water.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.

The bridge that needed room

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

Ari built a bridge from large blocks. A wide toy vehicle could not pass beneath it. Ari tried turning the vehicle, but it still stopped. Bea brought another block. Together they made the supports taller. The vehicle passed. Then Ari noticed the bridge wobbling. They stopped the game and rebuilt the base on the floor. This time the bridge stood firmly. “A wider opening and a steady bottom,” Ari said. Bea drove slowly through, and then it was Ari’s turn.

Teacher use

Revision; space and comparison; cooperation.

Large age-safe blocks and vehicles; build at a safe height, no climbing.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.

A message for the garden

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

The class had a small planter. One morning its soil needed checking. Sol helped the adult follow the plant-care routine. Afterward Sol wanted everyone to know the plant had been cared for. The adult asked, “What could our sign say?” Sol said, “Checked today.” The adult wrote the words and read them aloud. Sol added a picture and the date with help. They put the sign where the group could see it. Later, another child read the message with the adult. Tomorrow the plant would need another look, not a guess.

Teacher use

Meaningful print; purposeful care; explicit adult reading support.

Use an approved non-toxic plant; adults determine care and safe materials.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.

The book of the windy corner

Original short story • ages three to six, adapted to interest

Leah liked the windy corner of the yard. She told the adult, “My hat nearly flew.” The adult wrote her words, reading them back. Leah added a picture. On another page she drew a sheltered place. She asked how to write “hat.” The adult helped her listen to the sounds and connect them with letters at a suitable level. Together they read the little book. Leah changed one picture, then shared it with a friend who chose to listen. The windy corner had become a story they could return to.

Teacher use

Authorship; revision; timely direct literacy teaching.

Use a real local experience; no loose hats with unsafe ties or cords.

Tell naturally once, pause and follow the children’s response. Do not quiz for a moral. On another day, offer materials for an optional retelling or invite a child’s different ending.